# NATO 101

# A Guide to the Alliance's Purpose, Structure, and History

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# Section 1: Introduction to NATO

## Formation, History, and Primary Functions

The North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) was formed with the signing of the North Atlantic (or Washington) Treaty in 1949 as a political and military alliance between 12 states. Since then, it has grown to include 32 European and North American nations. Initially based in London, NATO's Headquarters was moved to Paris in 1952 before being transferred to Brussels in 1967.

During the Cold War (1949 to 1991) NATO (sometimes referred to as 'the Alliance') was dedicated overwhelmingly to the collective defense of its members (often referred to as 'the nations') by promoting a peaceful North Atlantic area and deterring threats from the Soviet Union and its Warsaw Pact allies. In the words of Lord Ismay, the Alliance's first Secretary General, the purpose of NATO was 'to keep the Americans in, the Russians out, and the Germans down.' In the quarter century after the Soviet Union dissolved, NATO enlarged significantly, championed democracy in Europe, and engaged in crisis management and other operations well beyond its traditional area of interest.

NATO's focus shifted following the Russian annexation of Ukrainian Crimea in 2014. NATO's Strategic Concept of 2022 outlines three core tasks: deterrence and defense, crisis prevention and management, and cooperative security. Since 2014, the Alliance has emphasized the first of these. The main challenges facing NATO today are (i) threats from the east in the form of renewed Russian bellicosity (as highlighted by the February 2022 invasion of Ukraine and ongoing 'grey-zone' attacks on Europe) and the consolidation of a Sino-Russian alliance; (ii) regional instability in areas of direct interest to NATO such as the Balkans (NATO has a peacekeeping force in Kosovo) and further 'out-of-area' (what is sometimes referred to as NATO's 'southern agenda'); (iii) interconnected threats such as, according to the Strategic Concept, 'climate change, fragile institutions, health emergencies and food insecurity'; (iv) and terrorism, which NATO regards as 'the most direct asymmetric threat to the security of the citizens of NATO countries, and to international peace and prosperity.'

## How NATO Works

*Consensus*

As a political-military alliance, it is very important that the NATO allies act in solidarity. A divided alliance would not be able to project the strength necessary for effective deterrence. Consequently, the Alliance's decision-making processes are based on the principle of consensus. If even one ally objects to an idea or proposal, it cannot be adopted. While this can certainly cause problems, the Alliance has generally been able to come to decisions that are agreeable to all its members. Its actions are more credible as a result. In reaching a decision, NATO works on the basis of the silence procedure – a proposal is worked up informally by groups of allies (or at the initiative of the Secretary General) and is then put before all the allies in one of NATO's committees. Unless an ally objects (i.e. 'breaks silence'), the proposal is regarded as having been adopted. NATO through this mechanism does not engage in formal votes.
(See: https://www.nato.int/cps/ic/natohq/topics_49178.htm )

*Strategy*

NATO's topline strategy document is its Strategic Concept. The most recent version was adopted in 2022 (replacing that of 2010). As already noted, that document sets out three core tasks: deterrence and defense, crisis prevention and management, and cooperative security. The Strategic Concept is, in essence, a political statement. It informs more detailed (often classified) documents on military doctrine and operational matters. A number of these were adopted in 2019-2020:

- The NATO Military Strategy (MC 400/4)
- Concept for the Defense and Deterrence of the North Atlantic Area (abbreviated to DDA)
- The Warfighting Capstone Concept

For discussion, see: https://www.atlanticcouncil.org/blogs/new-atlanticist/our-experts-decipher-natos-new-strategic-concept/

At the Vilnius summit in July 2023, NATO adopted a series of regional defense plans that reflected its evolving strategy. See: https://icds.ee/en/hague-summit-series-the-regional-defence-plans/#_ednref4. For how these plans remain relevant in 2026, see: https://www.iiss.org/online-analysis/military-balance/2026/07/natos-three-front-problem/

*Financing*

As a group of 32 states of widely varying sizes (including economic and military capability), NATO's budget and spending is subject to significant debate. This is usually referred to as the 'burden-sharing' issue. Indirect contributions are the largest financial contributions to NATO. These come, for instance, when an ally volunteers equipment or troops to a military operation or assigns military officers or diplomats to work at NATO Headquarters. These costs are usually shouldered by the ally concerned (on the basis of the principle of 'costs lie where they fall'). Direct contributions, the second form of NATO funding, are made to finance requirements of the Alliance that serve the interests of all members, such as NATO-wide commands. Here, costs are borne collectively and proportionately, often using the principle of common funding. With common funding, all the allies contribute according to an agreed cost-share formula based on Gross National Income (GNI). Common funding arrangements are also used to finance NATO's principal budgets: the civil budget, the military budget, and the NATO Security Investment Program. Additionally, projects can also be jointly funded by groups of allies, which means that the participating countries can identify the requirements, the priorities and the funding arrangements, but NATO provides political and financial oversight.
(see: https://www.nato.int/cps/em/natohq/topics_67655.htm ).

NATO has also laid down targets for national defense spending. At the Wales summit in September 2014, all allies agreed to 'move towards' spending at least two per cent of GDP on defense by 2024 with at least 20 per cent of that sum earmarked for the purchase of 'major new equipment' and research and development. At the 2024 summit in Washington, NATO leaders reiterated the two per cent target. The Washington Summit Declaration also affirmed that 'in many cases, expenditure beyond 2% of GDP will be needed in order to remedy existing shortfalls and meet the requirements across all domains arising from a more contested security order.' At the Hague summit in July 2025 a new target was set: the NATO allies 'commit[ed] to invest 5% of GDP annually on core defense requirements as well as defense-and security-related spending by 2035.' It was agreed that this 5% figure would comprise two elements: 3.5% of GDP would be dedicated to 'core defense requirements' in line with the already 'agreed definition of NATO defense expenditure.' The remaining 1.5% of GDP would go toward 'defense- and security-related spending' in order 'to protect our critical infrastructure, defend our networks, ensure our civil preparedness and resilience, unleash innovation, and strengthen our defense industrial base.'

NATO publishes an annual compendium that details allied defense expenditure. See: https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/topics_49198.htm

*Leadership*

NATO decision-making is led by the North Atlantic Council (the NAC) which meets at ambassadorial, ministerial, and heads of state and government levels. Day-to-day discussions involve NATO ambassadors and national delegations located at NATO HQ in Brussels, supported by the Secretary General (historically, a European politician or diplomat) and the Chair of the Military Committee (chosen by NATO Chiefs of Defence Staff). The Secretary General is supported by a Deputy, and several Assistant Secretaries General as well as the International Staff. The Military Committee is assisted by the International Military Staff. NATO's top military commanders are the Supreme Allied Commander Europe/SACEUR (an American General selected by the US president and approved by the NAC) and the Supreme Allied Commander Transformation/SACT (nominated by the allies and approved by the NAC). These civilian and military leaders oversee committees and groups across NATO's various commands, HQ and offices.

## Important Personnel

Secretary General: Mark Rutte (Netherlands)
Deputy Secretary General: Radmila Shekerinska (North Macedonia)
Chair of the Military Committee: Admiral Giuseppe Cavo Dragone (Italy)
Supreme Allied Commander Europe (SACEUR): General Alexus G. Grynkewich (USA)
Deputy SACEUR: Air Chief Marshal Sir Johnny Stringer (UK)
Supreme Allied Commander, Transformation (SACT): Admiral Pierre Vandier (France)
Deputy SACT: General Aurelio Colagrande (France)
(See: https://www.nato.int/en/about-us/organization/who-we-are )

## Members and Year of Accession

Belgium - 1949
Canada - 1949
Denmark - 1949
France - 1949
Iceland - 1949
Italy - 1949
Luxembourg - 1949
Netherlands - 1949
Norway - 1949
Portugal – 1949
United Kingdom - 1949
United States - 1949
Greece - 1952
Türkiye - 1952
Germany - 1955
Spain - 1982
Czech Republic - 1999
Hungary - 1999
Poland - 1999
Bulgaria - 2004
Estonia - 2004
Latvia – 2004
Lithuania - 2004
Romania - 2004
Slovakia - 2004
Slovenia - 2004
Albania – 2009
Croatia – 2009
Montenegro – 2017
N. Macedonia – 2020
Finland – 2023
Sweden - 2024

See: https://researchbriefings.files.parliament.uk/documents/CBP-9813/CBP-9813.pdf

# Section 2: NATO ‘s Civilian and Military Structures

## Principal Committees

- *North Atlantic Council (NAC)*

The NAC is the most important decision-making body within NATO. Its authority derives directly from the Washington Treaty (Article 9). It oversees and provides final decisions on all issues affecting the Alliance. Nothing involving NATO is out of the NAC’s purview.
https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/topics_49763.htm

- *Nuclear Planning Group (NPG)*

The NPG acts as the Alliance’s senior body on nuclear matters. Its discussions cover the safety, security and survivability of nuclear weapons, communications and information systems, deployment issues, nuclear arms control, and proliferation. Although a nuclear power, France has opted out of this body.
https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/topics_50069.htm

- *Military Committee (MC)*

The MC is NATO’s most senior military authority. It is the primary source of military advice to NATO’s civilian decision-making bodies. Its advice is sought prior to any authorization of military action. It represents an essential link between the political decision-making process and the NATO command structure.
https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/topics_49633.htm

## Reporting Committees

Reporting Committees are specialized bodies which report to the NAC. At present, there are 21 of these. Some of the most important are listed below:

| | |
|---|---|
| Deputies Committee | Partnerships and Cooperative Security Committee |
| Political Committee | Defense Policy and Planning Committee |
| Operations Policy Committee | Committee on Proliferation |

Conference of National Armaments Directors

https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/topics_49174.htm

## Dialogue Councils

These councils are the institutions of cooperation, partnership and dialogue that underpin relations between NATO and countries outside the alliance.

Euro-Atlantic Partnership Council (now largely inactive):
https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/topics_49276.htm

NATO-Russia Council (suspended since 2022):
https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/topics_50091.htm

NATO-Georgia Commission: https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/topics_38988.htm

NATO-Ukraine Council (formerly Commission):
https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/topics_37750.htm

## International Staff (IS)

The IS provides advice, guidance and administrative support to the national delegations at NATO Headquarters in order to help implement decisions taken at different committee levels. It is made up of the following divisions:

| | |
|---|---|
| Joint Intelligence and Security | Emerging Security Challenges |
| Political Affairs and Security Policy | Defense Policy and Planning |
| Operations | Defense Investment |
| Public Diplomacy | Executive Management |

(see: https://www.nato.int/cps/ra/natohq/topics_58110.htm)

## NATO Centers of Excellence (COE)

COEs are independent international military organizations that train and educate leaders and specialists from NATO member and partner countries. They assist in doctrine development, identify lessons learned, improve interoperability and capabilities, and test and validate concepts through experimentation. The most recently-established COEs deal with Climate Change and Security (based in Montreal, Canada) and Space (based in Toulouse, France).

Below is a list of other NATO-accredited COEs:

Analysis and Simulation for Air Operations
Civil-Military Cooperation
Cold Weather Operations
Combined Joint Operations from the Sea
Command and Control
Cooperative Cyber Defense
Counter-Improvised Explosive Devices
Counter Intelligence
Crisis Management and Disaster Response
Defense Against Terrorism
Energy Security
Explosive Ordnance Disposal
Human Intelligence
Integrated Air and Missile Defense
Joint Air Power
Joint CBRN Defense
Maritime Geospatial Information, Meteorology and Oceanography
Maritime Security
Military Engineering
Military Medicine
Military Police
Modelling and Simulation
Mountain Warfare
Naval Mine Warfare
Operations in Confined and Shallow Waters
Security Force Assistance
Stability Policing
Strategic Communication

(see: https://www.act.nato.int/about/centres-of-excellence/ )

## International Military Staff (IMS)

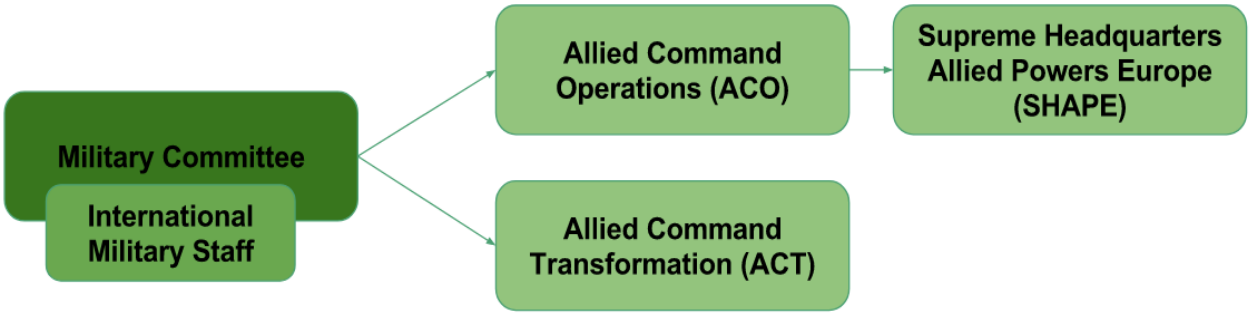
Made up of both civilian and military personnel, the role of the IMS is to provide strategic military advice and staff support to the Military Committee.

Plans and Policy Division
Operations Division
Intelligence Division
Cooperation and Regional Security Division
Logistics, Armaments & Resources Division
NATO Situation Centre
Financial Controller
Partner Country Representation
NATO Military Audiovisual Working Group
NATO Committee on Gender Perspective
NATO HQ Consultation, Control and Communications Staff (HQC3)

(See also: https://www.nato.int/cps/em/natohq/topics_49174.htm )

## The NATO Command Structure

NATO's top-level military structure is headed by the Military Committee supported by the International Military Staff (based at NATO Headquarters in Brussels) and answerable to the NAC (as described above). At a level below sit NATO's two Strategic Commands: Allied Command Operations (ACO) in Mons, Belgium, and Allied Command Transformation (ACT) in Norfolk, Virginia, United States.



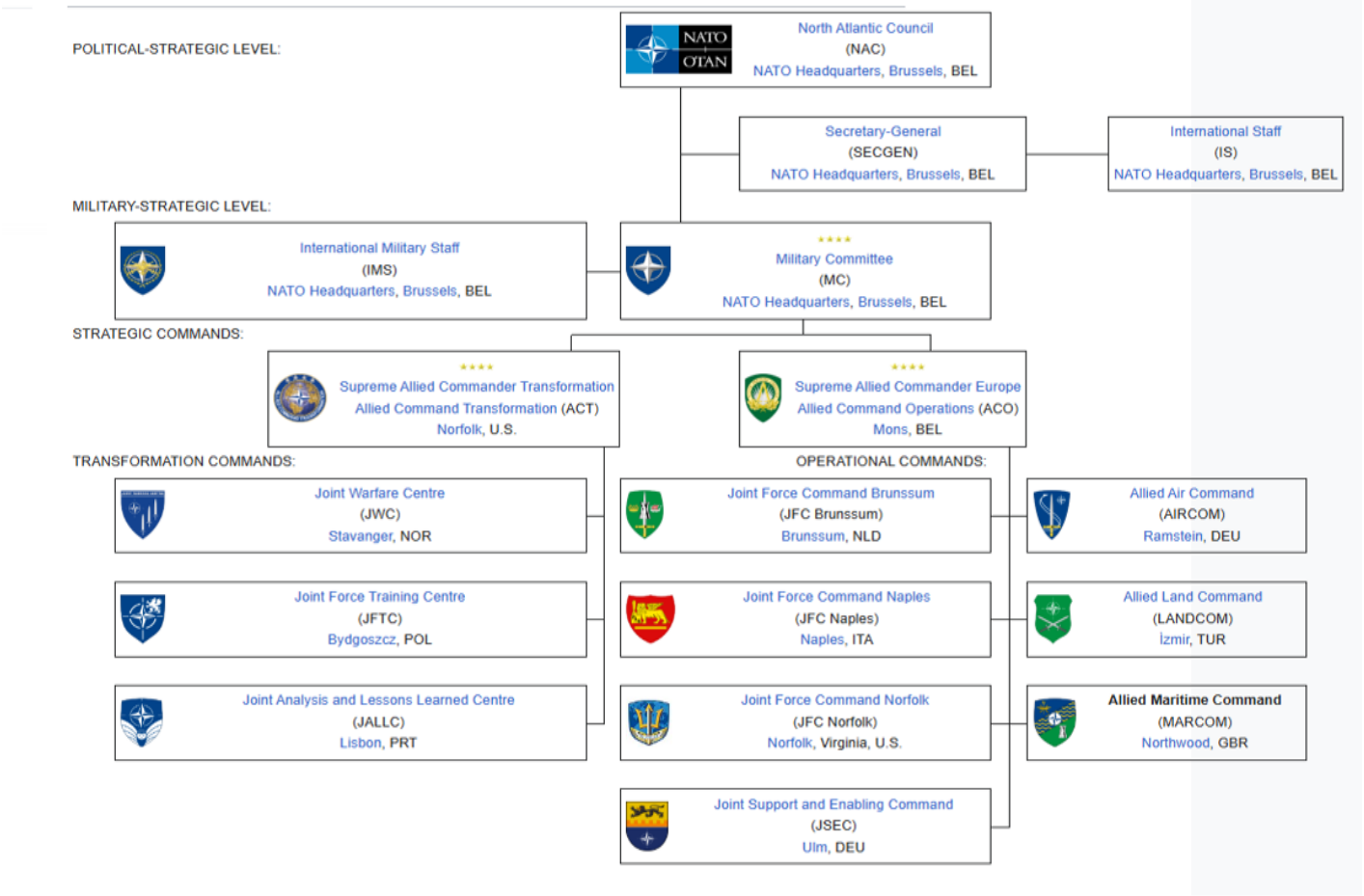

*Allied Command Operations (ACO)*

ACO is responsible for the planning and execution of all NATO military operations. The Supreme Allied Commander, Europe (SACEUR), who, despite his title, is responsible for all operations, regardless of location, assumes the command of operations at the strategic level at Supreme Headquarters Allied Powers Europe (SHAPE), located in Mons, Belgium. ACO/SACEUR oversees four Operational Commands and three Tactical Commands (sometimes known as Theatre Component Commands) relating to the air, land, and maritime domains (i.e. AIRCOM, LANDCOM and MARCOM).
https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/topics_52091.htm (see also the organigram on the next page). Allied Special Operations Forces Command (SOFCOM) is also located at SHAPE under an American commander who reports directly to SACEUR.
https://www.nshq.nato.int/

*Allied Command Transformation (ACT)*

ACT leads on the innovation of NATO forces, capabilities and doctrine. Its main responsibilities include education, training and exercises, as well as assessing new concepts, and promoting interoperability throughout the Alliance. Below ACT sit three Transformation Commands. ACT also oversees the work of the NATO Centers of Excellence and the NATO Defense College.
https://www.act.nato.int/

*NATO Command Structure (2026)*




https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Allied_Maritime_Command

## Important Military Units and Resources

*Command, control, communications, computers, intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance (C4ISR)*

Information gathering and surveillance have always been important to NATO. The Alliance possesses three main aerial tools. The first, the Boeing E-3A Sentry, commonly known as AWACs, is an airborne early warning and control aircraft. It provides all-weather surveillance, command, control, and communications. NATO currently owns 14 of these aircraft (with plans to have a replacement fleet in place by 2035). AWACs have been deployed by NATO as part of the anti-ISIS coalition and have been used to patrol the skies over Eastern Europe as part of NATO's deterrence posture. A fleet of five RQ-4D 'Phoenix' remotely-piloted aircraft is NATO's newest surveillance tool. Since September 2023, this fleet has been under NATO command operating as the NATO Intelligence, Surveillance and Reconnaissance Force as part of NATO's Joint Intelligence, Surveillance and Reconnaissance (JISR) effort (see: https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/topics_48892.htm ). A third initiative has taken NATO into outer space. In February 2023, NATO launched the Alliance Persistent Surveillance from Space (APSS) initiative with the aim of sharing satellite data from NATO-nation and commercial sources. During the course of 2024, NATO stood up the Combined Force Space Component Command (CFSpCC) and the NATO Space Operations Centre (NSpOC) at NATO Allied Air Command/AIRCOM, Ramstein (see: https://ac.nato.int/missions/we-coordinate-nato-space-matters )

*Joint Force Air Component (JFAC)*

NATO's JFAC is a specialized, quick response unit equipped for crisis response operations. Depending on the size of the operation, the JFAC may be specially tailored to meet the mission requirements. It can be supplemented from all Air Command entities or augmented from other NATO Air Forces or national JFACs as required for NATO missions. (see: https://ac.nato.int/missions/jfac )

*Forward Presence*

In 2016, as part of its enhanced Forward Presence (eFP), NATO agreed to deploy four multinational battalion battle groups to Estonia, Latvia, Lithuania and Poland. Simultaneously, NATO developed a tailored Forward Presence (tFP) in the south-eastern part of Alliance territory. Both the eFP and tFP were reinforced following the Russian invasion of Ukraine. The extraordinary meeting of NATO Heads of State and Government in March 2022 agreed to set up four multinational battlegroups in Bulgaria, Hungary, Romania and Slovakia. Following Finland's accession to NATO, a new NATO Multi-Corps Land Component Command (based in southeastern Finland) was declared operational in September 2025.

Taken together, NATO now has nine multinational battlegroups which comprise its Forward Land Forces (FLF) (see: https://shape.nato.int/efp ). These land forces are complemented by air-policing missions that cover the Baltic States, Poland, Bulgaria and Romania – as well as the Baltic and Black Seas. In September 2025, NATO launched Operation Eastern Sentry following Russian airspace violations of Poland. Described as a multi-domain operation, Eastern Sentry's main function has been air defense with several NATO nations (the UK, France, Denmark, Germany, Italy) deploying extra aircraft to defend Polish and Baltic airspace. NATO also has plans (in concert with the EU) to develop a 'drone wall' along its eastern flank. In the maritime domain, in 2024 NATO stood up Task Force Baltic. Its commander oversees Baltic Sentry, a maritime mission agreed in January 2025 to monitor Russian naval movements and protect undersea cables.
(see: https://researchbriefings.files.parliament.uk/documents/CBP-9450/CBP-9450.pdf )

*NATO Force Integration Units (NFIUs)*
As part of NATO's adaptation to security challenges from the east and the south, in 2016 the Alliance established eight Force Integration Units in Bulgaria, Estonia, Hungary, Latvia, Lithuania, Poland, Romania and Slovakia. These small headquarters facilitate the rapid deployment of forces to the eastern part of the Alliance, support collective defense planning and assist in coordinating training and exercises. They also work with host nations to identify logistical networks, transportation routes and supporting infrastructure to ensure that NATO's high-readiness forces can deploy as quickly as possible and work together effectively.
(see: https://shape.nato.int/operations/nato-force-integration-units )

*NATO Response Force (NRF)*
The NRF was established in 2002 as a high-readiness force capable of rapid deployment. It is designed to perform a wide variety of tasks including immediate collective defense response, crisis management, peace support operations, disaster relief, and the protection of critical infrastructure. At the 2014 Wales Summit, the Alliance decided to enhance the NRF by restructuring it into seven components numbering 40,000 troops in total. The most significant component was the Very High Readiness Joint Task Force (VJTF) which consisted of about 20,000 troops and included land, air, maritime and special operations components. The VJTF was backed by the Initial Follow-On Forces Groups (IFFG). Elements of the NRF were deployed to Afghanistan in the summer of 2021 to assist with the evacuation of Afghans involved in the departing NATO mission in the country. In response to the Russian invasion of Ukraine, NATO in February 2022 activated defense plans that allowed for the deployment of the NRF/VJTF. The NRF was premised on the allies making available up to 40,000 troops at short notice.

*The New NATO Force Model (incorporating the Allied Reaction Force)*
The NATO Madrid Summit in July 2022 agreed to replace the NRF with a new NATO Force Model involving 300,000 troops at high readiness (100,000 Tier 1 Forces would be ready at 10 days' notice; a further 200,000 troops would be ready within 30 days' notice). (See: https://www.nato.int/en/what-we-do/deterrence-and-defence/nato-force-model ) In parallel, a new Allied Reaction Force was planned to replace the VJTF. For analysis of this new force configuration, see: https://www.ndc.nato.int/the-new-nato-force-model-ready-for-launch/ . The NATO Force Model is the basis for determining commitments by the allies to deterrence. In February 2026, the United States outlined a plan for a 'NATO 3.0' which would require 'much greater efforts by our allies to step up and assume primary responsibility for the conventional defense of Europe.' In parallel, the United States notified the allies that it was reducing its commitment to the NATO Force Model and expected the European allies and Canada to plug the gaps. Shortly before the 2026 Ankara summit, the SACEUR, General Alexis Grynkewich stated: 'in a matter of weeks, European Allies have largely filled the gaps left by U.S. reductions to the NATO Force Model.' Doubts have been raised, however, as to how substantive these on-paper promises will be in practice.

*Standing Naval Forces (SNFs)*
NATO's SNFs provide the Alliance with a continuous naval presence. These forces can be deployed rapidly at times of crisis or tension. The SNFs consist of four groups: Standing NATO Maritime Groups 1 and 2 (SNMG1 and SNMG2) and Standing NATO Mine Countermeasures Groups 1 and 2 (SNMCMG1 and SNMCMG2). The SNMGs are multinational, integrated maritime forces made up of vessels from various allied countries. These vessels are permanently available to NATO to perform different tasks ranging from exercises to operational missions. SNMG1 is the designated maritime component of the NRF and operates in the North Atlantic, the North Sea and the Baltic region. SNMG2 deploys to the Mediterranean and the Black Sea and has been used for NATO naval missions off the coast of east Africa/Gulf of Aden. SNMGs have, in recent years, been concerned with monitoring Russian naval forces. The SNMCMGs are multinational forces that primarily engage in search and explosive ordnance disposal operations (see: https://shape.nato.int/about/aco-capabilities2/nato-standing-naval-forces )

*Framework Nation Concept*
NATO has long worked on the basis of lead or framework nations – a key ally which oversees force generation and command in a particular theatre of operation (such as Kosovo or Afghanistan, for example, and the eight battlegroups which make up NATO's Forward Land Forces) or a particular specialism (the United States is the framework nation for Allied Special Forces). Distinct from this, the Alliance at its summit in Wales in

September 2014 endorsed the Framework Nations Concept which emphasized ‘groups of Allies coming together to work multi-nationally for the joint development of forces and capabilities.’ Such a ‘framework’ would be led by a key ally. These frameworks tend to be loosely structured (they are outside of the NATO Command and Force Structure). The most significant NATO-aligned framework is the Joint Expeditionary Force, led by the UK with the participation of nine NATO allies. See: https://jefnations.org/ In addition, Germany is designated as a NATO ‘framework nation’ and has led on the organization of training and exercises. An Italian initiative has been geared toward training and future operations in the Mediterranean region.

# Section 3: NATO Partnerships

## Partnership Programs

*Partnership for Peace (PfP)*

Partnership for Peace is a program of bilateral cooperation between individual Euro-Atlantic partner countries and NATO. Begun in 1994, PfP covers all areas of NATO's activities. Some countries choose to deepen their cooperation with NATO by developing Individual Partnership Action Plans (IPAPs). Many PfP participants have since become full members of NATO. The PfP program currently has 18 members: Armenia, Austria, Azerbaijan, Belarus (suspended), Bosnia & Herzegovina, Georgia, Ireland, Kazakhstan, Kyrghyz Republic, Malta, Moldova, Russia (suspended), Serbia, Switzerland, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan, Ukraine, and Uzbekistan. Cooperation is intense with some (e.g. Ukraine) and almost non-existent with others (Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan). PfP with Belarus and Russia is currently suspended.

*Mediterranean Dialogue (MD)*

The Mediterranean Dialogue, a partnership with states in North Africa and the Levant, was created in 1994. Its overall aim is to contribute to regional security and stability, achieve better mutual understanding, and dispel misconceptions about NATO among Dialogue countries. It is based upon the twin pillars of political dialogue and practical cooperation. The MD currently has seven members: Algeria, Egypt, Israel, Jordan, Mauritania, Morocco and Tunisia.
(see: https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/topics_52927.htm )

*Istanbul Cooperation Initiative (ICI)*

The ICI, launched in June of 2004, aims to contribute to long-term global and regional security by offering countries of the Arab Gulf region practical bilateral security cooperation with NATO. ICI focuses on practical cooperation in areas where NATO can add value, notably in the security field. The ICI currently has four members: Bahrain, Qatar, Kuwait and the United Arab Emirates. Saudi Arabia and Oman have also shown an interest in the Initiative but have not joined for various reasons.
(see: https://www.nato.int/cps/ic/natohq/topics_52956.htm )

*Partners across the Globe*

In addition to its formal partnership programs, NATO cooperates with a range of countries on an individually-tailored basis. Some of these countries contribute actively to NATO operations either militarily or in some other way. Nine countries currently have this relationship: Afghanistan, Australia, Colombia, Iraq, Japan, Republic of Korea, Mongolia, New Zealand, and Pakistan. In June 2021 at the Brussels Summit, Allies agreed that the

inclusion of key actors from beyond the Euro-Atlantic area in the future would strengthen NATO engagement. The leaders of Australia, Japan, New Zealand, and South Korea (known as the Indo-Pacific or Asia-Pacific 4/AP4) attended their first ever NATO summit in June 2022 (in Madrid). They went on to attend the summits in Vilnius (2023) and Washington DC (2024) (but not the 2025 or 2026 summits).

*Partnership Interoperability Initiative (PII)*
At the 2014 Wales summit, NATO launched the PII – a program designed to 'maintain and deepen the interoperability that has been developed with partners during NATO-led operations and missions over the last decades.' The PII is made up of two components: the Interoperability Platform, which involves 23 partners, and the Enhanced Opportunities element which offers to five countries - Australia, Georgia, Jordan, Sweden, and Ukraine - 'tailor made [...] deeper cooperation.' (Sweden moved out of this initiative once it joined NATO in March 2024).
(see: https://www.nato.int/en/what-we-do/partnerships-and-cooperation/partnership-interoperability-initiative )

*Relations with the European Union*
NATO-EU relations are covered by a variety of agreements dating from 2001. The 2016, 2018 and 2023 Joint Declarations have given rise to a program of cooperation that embraces military mobility, cyber defense, counter-hybrid warfare, and counterterrorism. Cooperation between the two organizations has deepened as a consequence of the ongoing Russia-Ukraine war. Both organizations share an interest in boosting military spending, ramping up armaments production and improving military mobility on the European continent. In Kosovo, a NATO force (KFOR) works alongside an EU one (EULEX). NATO and the EU currently have 23 member countries in common. Türkiye, Norway, Iceland, the United Kingdom, the United States, and Canada are NATO members but not in the EU. Austria, Cyprus, Ireland, and Malta are in the EU but not in NATO. These membership asymmetries can pose problems of coordination between the two organizations – https://www.friendsofeurope.org/insights/critical-thinking-eu-nato-relations-time-to-step-up-a-gear-or-two/
(see also: https://www.nato.int/cps/ua/natohq/topics_49217.htm)

## Bilateral Relations

*Georgia*
Despite significant Russian opposition, Georgia has sought closer ties to NATO, and eventual membership. Georgia was the first of NATO's partners to forge an Individual Partnership Action Plan (IPAP). In 2014 it was given the status of an Enhanced

Opportunities Partner. Membership of NATO, however, has proven elusive. A non-binding referendum in January 2008 resulted in 72.5 percent of voters supporting NATO accession. NATO's Bucharest summit in April that year could not agree on a Membership Action Plan (MAP) for Georgia but did clearly state that the country would one day join the Alliance. This, in turn, provoked Russian hostility and was a major factor in the Russo-Georgia war of August. Russian forces have occupied Abkhazia and South Ossetia ever since. In June 2014, diplomats from NATO suggested that while a MAP was unlikely, a package of 'reinforced cooperation' was a possible compromise, to include military capabilities and armed forces training. Further measures were agreed at the 2016 and 2018 NATO summits. NATO Foreign Ministers in November 2020 agreed on a 'Substantial NATO-Georgia Package.' As Georgia is one of NATOs partners that is most greatly affected by Russia's war of aggression against Ukraine, Allies endorsed tailored support measures at the 2022 Madrid Summit. However, under the Georgia Dream government, the country has assumed a more skeptical view of NATO.
(See: https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/topics_38988.htm )

*Ukraine*
Ukraine joined NATO's Partnership for Peace initiative in 1994. In 1997, Ukraine and NATO signed the Charter on a Distinctive Partnership. Then, in April 2005, Ukraine entered into an Intensified Dialogue program with the alliance. In March 2008, Ukraine sent an official letter of application for a MAP (see also Georgia above). NATO at its summit in Bucharest the following month denied Ukraine access to MAP but stated that, along with Georgia, Ukraine would one day join the Alliance. In June 2010 the Ukrainian parliament voted to exclude the goal of 'integration into Euro-Atlantic security and NATO membership' from the country's National Security Strategy in a bill drafted by newly elected President Yanukovych. In February 2014, Yanukovych was removed from office by the Ukrainian Parliament. At the same time, pro-Russian unrest occurred in eastern Ukraine and Crimea was annexed by the Russian Federation a month later. Following this, Prime Minister Yatsenyuk announced his intention to resume the bid for NATO integration. The Ukrainian parliament in June 2017 voted in favor of NATO membership as a strategic objective of Ukraine and in 2019 the constitution was amended to include that ambition. The 2020 Ukrainian National Security Strategy repeats that position. NATO, in parallel, strengthened its links. In June 2020, Ukraine was recognized as an Enhanced Opportunities Partner of the Alliance. Russia has rejected Ukraine's strategic direction, and used the prospect of NATO membership as a pretext for its invasion of the country in February 2022. Individual NATO allies have provided considerable military assistance to Ukraine during this conflict, but have ruled out direct intervention (including the establishment of a no-fly-zone or military support for humanitarian corridors) (see:

https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natolive/topics_37750.htm and https://commonslibrary.parliament.uk/research-briefings/cbp-9477/ ).

In September 2022, Ukraine made a formal request to join NATO. The allies are divided on moving forward with this request. The Vilnius summit the following July, offered only 'to extend an invitation to Ukraine to join the Alliance when Allies agree and conditions are met.' The 2024 Washington summit repeated this formulation. The second Trump administration does not support Ukrainian accession (it is also opposed by Hungary and Slovakia). Reference was, therefore, absent from the 2025 Hague summit declaration

At the 2024 Washington summit, the allies agreed on three new initiatives to support Ukraine's war effort. The first was the establishment of NATO Security Assistance and Training for Ukraine (NSATU) to better coordinate the training of Ukrainian personnel and the delivery of arms and security assistance. This new command would be led by a three-star US officer (reporting to SACEUR), based in Weisbaden, Germany. NSATU would work alongside the main (non-NATO) mechanism for coordinating arms deliveries – the US-led Ukraine Defence Contact Group based in Ramstein, Germany. The second initiative was the creation of a new Joint Analysis Training and Education Centre (to be located in Poland) to promote the inter-operability of Ukraine's forces with NATO. Thirdly, NATO appointed a senior representative to the NATO Representation in Ukraine (NRU) (see: https://shape.nato.int/nsatu ).

The Trump administration, upon taking office in January 2025, terminated free arms transfers to Ukraine. In response, the NATO allies devised the Prioritized Ukraine Requirements List (PURL), a means by which these countries fund the purchase of American weapons on Ukraine's behalf. See: https://mod.gov.ua/en/news/how-nato-european-partners-and-the-united-states-are-strengthening-ukraine-through-the-purl-initiative and https://natowatch.org/sites/default/files/2025-10/nato_watch_briefing_129_defence_ministers.pdf

*Bosnia-Herzegovina*

Bosnia and Herzegovina joined the Partnership for Peace in 2006, signed an agreement on security cooperation in March 2007 and an IPAP in January 2008. The country started the process of Intensified Dialogue at the 2008 Bucharest summit. In September 2008, Bosnia-Herzegovina was invited to join the Adriatic Charter of NATO aspirants. In 2009 it lodged an official application for NATO membership and was extended a NATO Membership Action Plan in 2010. At NATO's 2022 Madrid summit, a new Defense Capacity Building Package was offered to Bosnia- Herzegovina. (see: https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/topics_49127.htm ).

*Others*

Various other European states have relationships with the Alliance that vary in nature and intensity. Cyprus is not involved with NATO in any formal way due to Türkiye's opposition. Serbia's attitude to the Alliance soured during the 1990s owing to NATO interventions in the Balkans. Serbia also maintains close ties to Russia and China and has adopted a policy of military neutrality. Armenia, Belarus, and Kazakhstan are all members of the Russian-led Collective Security Treaty Organization (CSTO), which is positioned against NATO. Azerbaijan has committed to a policy of neutrality, but has not ruled out eventually joining NATO. Mexican membership of NATO was once proposed in order to promote a 'North American pillar' of regional security. Israel and Morocco have occasionally been touted as potential NATO members. However, countries outside of Europe are currently precluded from NATO membership under the terms of Article 10 of the North Atlantic Treaty.

# Section 4: NATO Deterrence and Defense

## NATO's Force Posture

For NATO, the focus on deterrence and defense is a response to Russian action. Russia's hostile acts include, most importantly, its annexation of Ukrainian Crimea in 2014, military involvement in eastern Ukraine after 2014 and the full-scale war on Ukraine launched in February 2022. Ukraine is not a NATO member, but Russia's attack on the country has led to fears that Moscow may have similar ambitions toward some NATO allies (especially the Baltic States). The Russia war effort has been supported by Beijing, and while China is not a direct threat to any NATO ally, there is growing concern that China's rapid military expansion (especially its navy and nuclear arsenal) could in alliance with Russia pose a long-term threat to NATO interests - in the Arctic region, for instance.

NATO's view of Russia as a threat has been mentioned in all NATO summit declarations since 2014 and is central to the 2022 Strategic Concept. China has been seen as an object of concern in NATO statements since 2019 (although it was omitted from the 2025 and 2026 summit declarations).

Collective defense is, according to the 2022 Strategic Concept, 'NATO's key purpose.' NATO recognizes deterrence and defense across five domains: land, air, maritime, cyber and space. It is thus committed to preparing for and mounting operations that are 'multi-domain.'

NATO deterrence and defense is underpinned by defense spending commitments (see the 2014 Wales and 2025 Hague commitments already noted), capability targets (a new set was agreed by NATO defense ministers in June 2025), the NATO Defense Planning Process and a series of classified planning documents (see the regional defense plans noted on p.4). The NATO allies have also recently agreed measures to accelerate defence production. In February 2025, NATO defence ministers adopted an Updated Defense Production Action Plan. A Strategy for Industry-NATO Cooperation was agreed at the 2026 Ankara summit.

The NATO Command and Force Structures (see pp.9-11) are the organizational backbone of deterrence and defense. The military resources of NATO detailed on pp.12-15 are also vital. A detailed overview of how all these NATO assets combine can be found in the latest *Annual Report* of the NATO Secretary General (see pp.9-18 at: https://www.nato.int/en/about-us/official-texts-and-resources/secretary-generals-annual-report/secretary-generals-annual-report-2025

NATO deterrence and defense is also supported by the activities detailed below.

## Nuclear Weapons

Three of NATO's members are nuclear weapons' states – France, the United Kingdom and the United States. France, however, has opted out of NATO nuclear sharing arrangements, does not participate in the NATO Nuclear Planning Group, and does not formally assign its nuclear weapons to NATO. In March 2026, the French president Emmanuel Macron, announced an 'advanced deterrence' strategy which would see some NATO allies cooperate with France on nuclear matters. However, there was no explicit commitment given by France to provide any other country with a nuclear defense guarantee.

The nuclear strategies of the United Kingdom and the United States, by contrast, allow for extended nuclear deterrence (i.e. the use of national nuclear weapons for the defense of allies). American tactical nuclear weapons are also the basis of NATO nuclear-sharing arrangements. At present, US-controlled nuclear weapons are located in Belgium, Germany, Italy, the Netherlands and Türkiye (in June 2025, the British government announced it was also willing to host such weapons). They are designed to be delivered by 'dual-capable aircraft' of the host nation. NATO's agreed position on nuclear weapons is set out authoritatively in the 2012 Deterrence and Defense Posture Review. This document states that '[a]s long as nuclear weapons exist, NATO will remain a nuclear alliance.' NATO does not itself have legal personality and so does not sign treaties. It does, however, support American efforts at nuclear arms control (most obviously in relation to the US-Russian START Treaty) and has backed an American decision (in August 2019) to withdraw from the 1987 Intermediate Nuclear Forces (INF) Treaty over allegations of Russian non-compliance. The agreed NATO position is to support the Comprehensive Test Ban Treaty and the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty. In December 2020, NATO issued a statement agreed by consensus, critical of the Treaty on the Prohibition of Nuclear Weapons (otherwise known as the Nuclear Ban Treaty). The Ban Treaty has been signed by 84 states and entered into force in late January 2021. The NATO position is that the treaty 'lacks any rigorous or clear mechanisms for verification, and has not been signed by any state that possesses nuclear weapons, and thus will not result in the elimination of a single nuclear weapon.' NATO's current nuclear policy is based on the 2022 Strategic Concept, the 2012 Deterrence and Defense Posture Review, and the 2020 DDA (see p.4) For a summary of NATO nuclear policy, see: https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/topics_50068.htm and https://thebulletin.org/premium/2023-11/nuclear-weapons-sharing-2023/

## Integrated Air and Missile Defense (IAMD)

NATO possesses an integrated Air Command and Control System (overseen by NATO AIRCOM) that covers European NATO airspace (the United States and Canada are covered separately by the North American Aerospace Defense Command/NORAD). NATO air policing and AWAC missions are part of this system as are early-warning systems that monitor potentially hostile (i.e. Russian) aerial activities. In addition, NATO has a Ballistic Missile Defense (BMD) capability made up of commonly-funded command and control systems and national (mainly American)-provided assets stationed across several European and Turkish locations. BMD deployments have been publicly justified as guarding against Iranian or terrorist attack, but also have a growing relevance in deterring Russia (see: https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/topics_49635.htm)

## Cyber Defense

Since the mid-2000s, NATO has developed cyber policies devoted to protecting common assets (NATO Headquarters and the Command Structure) and formulating guidance for its member nations. The first NATO Cyber Defense Policy was adopted in 2008 following a major Russian cyber attack on Estonia. Cyber defense was introduced into the NATO Defense Planning Process in 2012. At the 2014 Wales NATO summit cyber defence was recognized as falling under NATO's collective defence obligations (Article 5 of the North Atlantic Treaty). The 2016 Warsaw summit recognized cyber as a domain of operations for NATO. That summit also adopted the Cyber Defense Pledge (updated at the Vilnius summit in 2023). NATO has a Cyber Security Center (embedded in SHAPE), a Cyber Operations Center (located in northern Italy) and a Cooperative Cyber Defense Centre of Excellence (in Tallinn, Estonia). The NATO Computer Incident Response Capability (NCIRC) is designed to provide protection of NATO's networks. Additionally, NATO aims to integrate cyber defense into the entire range of Alliance exercises, including the annual Crisis Management Exercise (CMX). NATO is also enhancing its capabilities for cyber education. through the NATO Industry Cyber Partnership (NICP)
(see: https://www.nato.int/en/what-we-do/deterrence-and-defence/cyber-defence )

## Space

In 2019, NATO adopted a Space Policy and identified space as a fifth operational domain (alongside land, air, maritime and cyber). The establishment of the NATO Space Operations Centre and the Combined Force Space Component Command followed (see p.22). The focus of NATO's space policy is satellite communication with data being used to support NATO operations, deployments and exercises, and communication across the Command Structure. Up until 2005, NATO operated its own satellites. Since then, it has relied on satellites operated by the United States, Italy, France and the UK. Spain and

Luxembourg have recently agreed to provide satellite access to NATO. These providers make up the NSS6G consortium. NATO endorsed a Commercial Space Strategy in 2025 with a view to accessing satellites from non-governmental providers.
https://www.act.nato.int/our-work/network-community/natos-approach-to-space/
https://www.defense.gov/News/News-Stories/Article/Article/3819541/two-new-nations-join-program-to-provide-satcom-support-to-nato/

## Technological Innovation

NATO is currently focused on harnessing 'disruptive' technologies such as artificial intelligence and quantum computing, and in pursuing collaborative projects on state-of – the art capabilities (drones, precision-guided weapons, electronic jamming). In October 2021, NATO launched an Innovation Fund. In 2023 it initiated a Defense Innovation Accelerator (DIANA) [ https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/topics_216199.htm ]. NATO has recently adopted strategies on emerging and disruptive technologies (2021), AI (2021, revised in 2024), quantum technologies (2024), and biotechnology and human enhancement technologies (2024).

## Exercises

NATO engages in a constant program of exercises and training designed to test operational readiness and to maintain inter-operability among both allies and NATO partners. Exercises take three forms: live exercises, command post exercises and an exercise study. As well as NATO exercises (defined as being initiated or co-initiated by the Alliance) individual nations organize multi-national exercises ('allied national exercises'), which reinforce NATO objectives. Since the down-turn in relations with Russia after the 2014 Crimea crisis, NATO and national exercises have obtained a clearer focus on Article 5 (collective defense) contingencies.

You can see detail of NATO exercises in 2026 here: https://www.grosswald.org/nato-exercises-2026/ For an overview of NATO exercises, see: https://shape.nato.int/exercises

# Section 5: NATO Operations

Up until its turn toward collective defense in 2014, NATO was preoccupied with missions, usually geared toward conflict management. NATO has also undertaken training, counter-piracy and counter-terrorism missions.

These missions are very different from the deterrence and defense posture noted in the previous section.

A full list of NATO operations is available on the NATO website:
https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/topics_52060.htm

## Completed Operations

*Operation Anchor Guard - August 1990 to March 1991*
After Iraqi forces invaded Kuwait on 2 August 1990, NATO Airborne Early Warning aircraft deployed to Konya, Türkiye, to monitor the crisis and provide coverage of southeastern Türkiye in case of an Iraqi attack during the first Gulf Crisis/War.

*Operation Ace Guard - January 1991 to March 1991*
In response to a request for assistance to meet the threat posed by Iraq during the first Gulf Crisis/War, NATO deployed the ACE Mobile Force (Air) and air defense packages to Türkiye.

*Bosnia and Herzegovina - July 1992 to December 2004*
NATO's mission in Bosnia and Herzegovina started with the enforcement of an arms embargo and a no-fly-zone declared by the UN in 1992. Operation Deadeye began in the summer of 1995 with a bombing campaign against Bosnian Serb air forces, but failed to result in Bosnian Serb compliance with the UN's demands to withdraw. Operation Deliberate Force targeted Bosnian Serb command and control installations and ammunition facilities. With the signing of the Dayton Peace Accord in December 1995, NATO immediately deployed a UN-mandated Implementation Force (IFOR) as part of Operation Joint Endeavour. This was followed in December 1996 by the deployment of a Stabilisation Force (SFOR). NATO brought its peace-support operation to a conclusion in December 2004 and the European Union deployed a new force called Operation Althea.

*Kosovo/Yugoslavia: Operation Allied Force – March - June 1999*
Following the failure of peace talks aimed at ending Serb attacks on the ethnic Albanian population in Kosovo (a province of Serbia), NATO launched Operation Allied Force (OAF).

This campaign on targets in the Federal Republic of Yugoslavia (Serbia and Montenegro) involved aerial sorties and sea-launched missile strikes. NATO action was geared toward a withdrawal of Serb forces from Kosovo so as to pave the way for a return of refugees and a political settlement. After a 78-day campaign, the Yugoslav leadership agreed to a peace deal brokered by Finnish and Russian mediators. That agreement was, in turn, the basis for UNSCR 1244 and a military-technical agreement (the Kumanovo agreement) between NATO and Yugoslavia/Serbia. These documents paved the way for the deployment of KFOR and the establishment of UNMIK (see p.28).

*Albania: Operation Allied Harbour – April – September 1999*
While OAF was underway, the Alliance deployed a NATO Albania Force (AFOR) to deal with the humanitarian crisis caused by refugees fleeing Kosovo into Albania and Macedonia. AFOR facilitated the delivery of humanitarian aid into Albania and the construction of refugee camps. With the winding down of the operation, elements of AFOR transitioned to KFOR. Operation Allied Harbour was NATO's first ever humanitarian mission.

*Macedonia: Operation Essential Harvest - August 2001 to March 2003*
NATO played a significant role in support of Macedonia during the insurgency of the Albanian National Liberation Army. Operation Essential Harvest disarmed ethnic Albanian groups operating throughout the country. Operation Amber Fox provided protection for international monitors overseeing the implementation of the peace plan. Operation Allied Harmony began in December 2002 to provide advisory elements to assist the government in ensuring stability throughout FYROM. NATO remains committed to helping FYROM integrate into Euro-Atlantic structures. To that end, NATO Headquarters Skopje was created in April 2002 to advise on military aspects of security sector reform; it still operates today.

*Operation Eagle Assist - October 2001 to May 2002*
The Alliance's first-ever counter-terrorism operation came as a direct result of the attacks on 9/11 in the United States. Operation Eagle Assist utilized seven NATO AWACS radar aircraft to patrol the skies over the United States. This was the first time that NATO military assets were deployed in support of an Article 5 operation.

*Operation Active Endeavour - October 2001 to October 2016*
Initiated in the immediate aftermath of the 9/11 terrorist attacks to deter, defend, disrupt and protect against terrorist activity in the Mediterranean, Operation Active Endeavour began as an Article 5 operation. It developed into a full-scale effort to deter terrorism and secure one of the globe's largest trade routes. It was succeeded by Operation Sea Guardian in October 2016.

*Operation Display Deterrence - February to April 2003*
NATO deployed AWACS radar aircraft and air defense batteries to enhance the defense of Türkiye during the second Gulf War.

*NATO Training Mission in Iraq (NTM-I) - July 2004 to December 2011*
NTM-I was established to assist in the development of Iraqi security forces training structures. It was withdrawn from Iraq at the end of 2011 when the mandate of the mission expired and agreement could not be reached on the legal status of NATO troops operating in the country. A new mission was launched in 2018 (see above).

*Assisting the African Union in Darfur, Sudan - June 2005 to December 2007*
NATO provided air transport for the African Union Mission in Sudan (AMIS), as well as trained and mentored over 250 AMIS officials. NATO's support to this mission ended when AMIS was succeeded by the UN-AU Mission in Darfur (UNAMID), but the Alliance immediately expressed its readiness to consider any request for support to the new peacekeeping mission.

*Horn of Africa: counter-piracy - October 2008 to December 2016*
In cooperation with the United Nations and the EU, NATO took part in a number of counter-piracy operations. NATO-led Operation Allied Provider was conducted from October to December 2008 and involved counter-piracy activities off the coast of Somalia. From March to August 2009, NATO ran Operation Allied Protector, a counter-piracy operation off the Horn of Africa.The subsequent Operation Ocean Shield was a longer operation with a similar focus. It ended in 2016, having achieved its objectives.

*Afghanistan: International Security Assistance Force (ISAF) - August 2003 to December 2014*
Established at the request of the Afghan authorities and under a UN mandate granted in 2001, ISAF's mission was to develop new Afghan security forces and enable Afghan authorities to provide effective security across the country. In January 2015, NATO launched Resolute Support (see above), a non-combat mission, to train, advise and assist the Afghan security forces and institutions. ISAF was NATO's most challenging operation of the post-Cold War period. Approximately 3,500 NATO troops (the majority American) were killed in the mission.
(see: https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/topics_69366.htm )

*Afghanistan: Resolute Support Mission (RSM), Afghanistan - January 2015 to August 2021*
The follow-up to ISAF, NATO's current mission in Afghanistan is a non-combat mission which provides training, advice and assistance to Afghan security forces and institutions. Initially at a strength of some 17,000 personnel from both NATO and partner countries, the force has been wound down since 2016. A 2020 agreement between the US and the Taliban foresaw the removal of all foreign forces by May 2021. In April 2021, allied Foreign and Defense Ministers agreed to terminate the NATO mission in the country. All remaining NATO forces withdrew from Afghanistan in August 2021. NATO has since launched a lessons-learned exercise on the experience of Afghanistan:
https://www.nato.int/nato_static_fl2014/assets/pdf/2021/12/pdf/2112-factsheet-afgh-lessons-en.pdf

*Libya: Operation Unified Protector - March to October 2011*
This mission, authorized by the UN after the beginning of the Libyan civil war, had three distinct components: the enforcement of an arms embargo on the Mediterranean to prevent the transfer of arms, related material, and mercenaries to Libya; the enforcement of a no-fly-zone in order to prevent bombing civilian targets; and air and naval strikes against military forces involved in attacks or threats to attack Libyan civilians. The operation was terminated on 31 October 2011.
(see: https://www.nato.int/cps/ic/natohq/topics_71652.htm )

## Current Operations

*Kosovo: - June 1999 to present*
NATO troops (KFOR) first entered Kosovo in June 1999 following the conclusion of Operation Allied Force (see p.26) in order to uphold peace and support a UN-mandated administration (UNMIK). Following Kosovo's declaration of independence in February 2008, NATO agreed it would continue to maintain its presence. It has since helped to create a professional and multi-ethnic Kosovo Security Force.
https://jfcnaples.nato.int/kfor

As of October 2026, there were 4,700 personnel in KFOR drawn from 31 contributing nations. Italy provides the largest contingent followed by the United States, Hungary, Germany and Turkey. Several non-NATO partners also contribute including Armenia, Austria, Ireland and Switzerland. The force is run by the Commander KFOR (Com KFOR) located in the Kosovan capital Pristina; he oversees two regional commands (Kosovo East and West, under respectively American and Italian leadership). Com KFOR reports to

NATO's Joint Force Command in Naples (Italy). Like all NATO operations, ultimate operational oversight sits with Allied Command Operations and its strategic commander, the Supreme Allied Commander Europe (SACEUR). Politically, KFOR sits under the authority of the North Atlantic Council. KFOR was reinforced in 2023-2024 following instability in northern Kosovo (the area bordering Serbia). Under plans announced in June 2026, KFOR would be reduced within 12 months 'in line with conditions on the ground.' It is likely that if these reductions go ahead, the US contingent will be downsized to reflect Washington's demand that the European allies shoulder greater responsibility in NATO.

*Bosnia: December 2004 to present.*
Since the termination of SFOR, the Alliance has maintained a military headquarters in Sarajevo to carry out a number of specific tasks related to assisting the Bosnian government in reforming its defense structures. This is related to Bosnia's Membership Action Plan.

*Sea Guardian – November 2016 to present*
Sea Guardian is the successor to Operation Active Endeavour (see above) launched in the wake of 9/11. This Mediterranean maritime mission performs three tasks: maritime situational awareness, counter-terrorism at sea and support to capacity-building.
(see: https://mc.nato.int/missions/operation-sea-guardian.aspx )

*Supporting the African Union - June 2007 to present*
Since June 2007, NATO has assisted the AU Mission in Somalia (AMISOM*)* by providing airlift support for AU peacekeepers. NATO is also providing capacity-building support, as well as expert training support to the African Standby Force (ASF), at the AU's request. The ASF is intended to be deployed in Africa in times of crisis and is part of the AU's efforts to develop long-term peacekeeping capabilities.
(see: https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/topics_8191.htm )

*Assistance for the Refugee/Migrant Crisis in the Aegean Sea - February 2016 to present*
Following a request from Germany, Greece and Türkiye, NATO defense ministers decided in February 2016 to assist with the growing refugee and migrant crisis in Europe. Standing NATO Maritime Group 2 (SNMG2) has conducted reconnaissance, monitoring and surveillance of illegal crossings in the territorial waters of Greece and Türkiye, as well as in international waters. It shares relevant information with the Greek and Turkish coast guards and authorities, and with Frontex, the European Border and Coast Guard Agency.
(see: https://www.nato.int/cps/ra/natohq/topics_70759.htm )

*NATO Mission Iraq (NMI)*

Launched in Baghdad in October 2018, this is a 500-strong non-combat mission aimed at strengthening the Iraqi armed forces so preventing the re-emergence of ISIS as a powerful force in the country. NATO defense ministers agreed in February 2021 to expand the NATO Mission Iraq as requested by the Iraqi government. In March 2026, NATO personnel were relocated from Baghdad to NATO Joint Force Command Naples, from where the NMI mission continues.

(see: https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/topics_166936.htm )

# Section 6: Thematic Activities

## Political Consultation

NATO is often referred to as a political-military alliance. Much of the activity detailed in this Guide is military in nature, but NATO also engages in various types of political consultation. These activities are detailed here: https://www.nato.int/en/what-we-do/introduction-to-nato/the-consultation-process-and-article-4?selectedLocale=

Formally-speaking, Article 4 of the North Atlantic Treaty allows for consultation at times of crisis. The link above details the nine occasions the article has been invoked. Some decisions taken by the allies are highly political. Deciding on the admission of a new member can be very divisive, requiring a lot of negotiation by the allies and mediation by the Secretary General.

## Disaster Response

NATO has been involved in disaster response and civil emergency planning since as 1953 (when it aided the UK following floods in the east of England). This mission has grown in importance since the 1990s and NATO has helped both allies and partners including Albania, Georgia, Moldova, Pakistan, Portugal, Türkiye, Ukraine and the United States. NATO has assisted in relief efforts by airlifting supplies and deploying engineers, medical units and specialist equipment. The Alliance has responded to floods, earthquakes, forest fires, and the COVID-19 pandemic. NATO is assisted in these tasks by a Resilience Committee (formerly known as the Civil Emergency Planning Committee) and the Euro-Atlantic Disaster Response Coordination Centre (EADRCC).
https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/topics_52057.htm?

## Energy Security

While NATO is not an energy institution, energy developments, such as supply disruptions, affect the international security environment and can have far-reaching security implications for some allies. Emerging security challenges, like cyber and hybrid threats on infrastructure, as well as the energy crisis caused by Russia's attack on Ukraine have become increasingly more important. Though protecting energy infrastructure is primarily a national responsibility, NATO contributes in areas where it can add value, notably the exchange of best practices with partner countries, many of which are important energy producers or transit countries, and with other international institutions and the private sector. Additionally, NATO has taken steps to increase energy efficiency in the military by adopting a Green Defense framework in 2014 and created a group of experts, the Smart Energy Team (SENT), that works closely with other NATO stakeholders, such as military

engineers and fuel experts. NATO has overseen a European Pipeline System since 1959. (see: https://www.nato.int/cps/ic/natohq/topics_49208.htm ). In July 2026, the allies agreed to a €27 billion NATO Fuel Supply Chain Capability Programme Plan.

## Resilience

NATO's response to natural disasters and the COVID-19 pandemic has shone a light on national resilience (a concept that also embraces how well a country can cope with internal political disruption and the integrity of its communication and transportation systems). Civil preparedness is an important element of the 'resilience challenge.' At the 2016 Warsaw summit NATO adopted seven 'baseline requirements for national resilience.' One of these baseline requirements – on civil communications systems – was updated by the allies in October 2019 in response to the emergence of 5G technology. The June 2021 NATO summit issued a Strengthened Resilience Commitment and furthermore, under the 'NATO 2030' process, Heads of State and Government have agreed to enhance resilience consistent with Article 3 of the North Atlantic Treaty. The 2022 Strategic Concept states that 'ensuring our national and collective resilience is critical to all our core tasks.' NATO's Resilience Committee (backed by six specialist sub-committees) is the main body at NATO HQ that oversees work on these matters (see: https://www.act.nato.int/article/resilience-in-nato/ ).

## Science for Peace and Security (SPS) Program

The SPS Program promotes dialogue and practical cooperation between NATO countries and partner nations based on scientific research, technological innovation and knowledge exchange. The SPS Program offers funding, expert advice and support to tailor-made, security-relevant activities that respond to NATO's strategic objectives. It connects scientists, experts, and officials from allied and partner countries to address security challenges of every variety, from traditional concerns to cyber warfare, to the environment. (see: https://www.nato.int/en/about-us/organization/nato-structure/science-for-peace-and-security-hub/science-for-peace-and-security-programme?selectedLocale= )

## Counter-terrorism

NATO's Strategic Concept 'recognizes terrorism, in all its forms [...] as the most direct asymmetric threat to the security of NATO citizens and to international peace and prosperity.' Operation Active Endeavour and the International Security and Assistance Force (ISAF) mission in Afghanistan were both launched after 9/11 and so had a connection to counter-terrorism. NATO was also a member of the Global Coalition to Defeat ISIS and contributed to that mission through the provision of AWACS aircraft.

NATO undertakes the Defense against Terrorism Program of Work (DAT POW). The aim of

DAT POW is to prevent non-conventional attacks, such as suicide attacks with improvised explosive devices (IEDs), and mitigate other challenges, such as attacks on critical infrastructure. DAT POW projects are consolidated under three capability umbrellas: incident management, force protection and survivability, and network engagement. CT also informs work with the EU and with NATO's southern partners. To that end, in September 2017, NATO initiated the 'NATO Strategic Direction South Hub' based at NATO's Joint Force Command in Naples, Italy and at the 2024 Washington summit adopted a Southern Neighbourhood Action Plan.

Since 2017, has had a Terrorism Intelligence Cell located within Joint Intelligence Security Division at NATO HQ. In 2023, NATO appointed a Special Coordinator for Counter-Terrorism. At the 2024 Washington summit, NATO adopted updated Policy Guidelines on Counter-Terrorism. (see: https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/topics_77646.htm )

## Weapons of Mass Destruction (WMD)

NATO has taken many steps to prevent WMD proliferation, deter potential attacks, and be prepared for recovery operations should an atack occur. The Alliance stepped up its activities in this area in 1999 with the launch of the WMD Initiative. This was designed to integrate political and military aspects of NATO's work in responding to the proliferation of WMD. The WMD Non-Proliferation Centre was launched in May 2000 as a result. NATO continues to significantly improve its CBRN defense posture with the establishment of the Combined Joint CBRN Defense Task Force (CJ-CBRND-TF) and multiple COEs related to this issue. Additionally, NATO creates and improves standardization documents, conducts training and exercises, and develops capability improvements in the field of CBRN defense through a variety of methods. Finally, under the auspices of the EADRCC, NATO allies have established an inventory of national civil and military capabilities that could be made available to assist stricken countries following a CBRN terrorist attack (see: https://www.nato.int/cps/ra/natohq/topics_50325.htm ).

## Climate Change

At its summit meeting in June 2021, NATO noted that climate change is a 'threat multiplier that impacts Alliance security.' The leaders of the Alliance agreed that NATO would aim to 'become the leading international organisation when it comes to understanding and adapting to the impact of climate change on security.' They also set 2050 as the target date by which allied militaries would be responsible for net zero emissions. In June 2022, NATO released its first Climate Change and Security Impact Assessment and called for a transformational approach to defense and security, setting NATO as a leader in recognizing and adapting to climate change. NATO released further assessments in 2023 and 2024. In October 2024, a NATO Climate Change and Security Centre of Excellence

opened in Montréal. For further detail and analysis, see:
https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/14702436.2025.2474074#d1e198

## Interoperability

NATO defines interoperability as 'the ability [of] Allies to act together coherently, effectively and efficiently to achieve tactical, operational and strategic objectives.' It is essential in operations and is promoted through exercises, the dissemination of Allied Joint Doctrine and Standardization Agreements (STANAGs).
https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/topics_84112.htm
A full list of Allied Joint Doctrine documents is at:
https://www.gov.uk/government/collections/allied-joint-publication-ajp

## Women, Peace and Security (WPS)

In the 2024 Washington summit declaration, NATO 'endorsed an updated WPS Policy' geared toward enhancing 'the integration of gender perspectives across all of NATO's activities and structures, and [to] advance[ing] gender equality within the Alliance.' NATO's 2024 WPS Policy is aligned with ten UN Security Council Resolutions on WPS adopted between 2000 and 2019. That policy 'recognises the distinct and disproportionate impact that instability, crisis, conflict, and post-conflict situations have on women and girls.' Consistent with NATO's Human Security Agenda, the WPS Policy is alert to the problem of Conflict Related Sexual Violence (CRSV). NATO, the Policy notes, 'will aim to protect women and girls particularly from all forms of gender-based violence, including CRSV.' Implementation of the NATO WPS Policy is based on a WPS Action Plan 'that outlines concrete, measurable, and results-oriented actions across the NATO Enterprise.' The most recent iteration of that plan (approved by NATO Defense Ministers in October 2021) covered the period 2021-2025 and has now timed out.

# Section 7: NATO Acronyms and Abbreviations

A2/AD - Anti Access/Area Denial
ACO - Allied Command Operations
ACT - Allied Command Transformation
AJF - Allied Joint Force
AWACS - Airborne Warning And Control System
C2 - Command and Control
C3 - Consultation, Command, and Control
CBRN - Chemical, Biological, Radiological, and Nuclear
CFE - Conventional Forces in Europe (Treaty)
CFI - Connected Forces Initiative
CHOD - Chief of Defense
COE - Centre of Excellence
DAT POW - Defense Against Terrorism Program Of Work
DCA - Dual-Capable Aircraft
DCBI - Defense and Related Security Capacity Building Initiative
DDA – (Concept for the) for the Defense and Deterrence of the North Atlantic Area
DDPR - Deterrence and Defense Posture Review
DEEP - Defense Education Enhancement Program
DIANA – Defense Innovation Accelerator
DIP - Defense Investment Pledge
DDP - Defense Planning Process
DSACEUR – Deputy Allied Commander Europe
EAPC - Euro-Atlantic Partnership Council
EDI - European Deterrence Initiative
EDU - European Defense Union

eFP – enhanced Forward Presence
ESDI - European Security and Defense Identity
ETEE - Education, Training, Exercises, and Evaluation
EU CSDP - European Union Command Security and Defense Policy
FIU - Force Integration Units
ICI - Istanbul Cooperation Initiative
IPAP - Individual Partnership Action Plan
ISAF - International Security Assistance Force
JFC - Joint Forces Command
JISR - Joint Intelligence, Surveillance, and Reconnaissance
MAP - Membership Action Plan
MD - Mediterranean Dialogue
MJO - Major Joint Operation
NRF - NATO Response Force
NSD-E - NATO Strategic Direction East
NSD-S - NATO Strategic Direction South
NTM - Notice to Move
OODA - Observe, Orient, Decide, Act
PfP - Partnership for Peace
RAP- Readiness Action Plan
SHAPE - Supreme Headquarters Allied Powers Europe
SACEUR - Supreme Allied Commander Europe
SD - Smart Defense
SSR - Security Sector Reform
tFP - tailored Forward Presence
VJTF - Very High Readiness Joint Task Force ('Spearhead')

(see also the list of NATO acronyms at: https://www.canada.ca/en/department-national-defence/services/doing-business-with-foreign-defence-markets/annex-c-nato-acronyms.html)

# Section 8: Further Reading

For authoritative information on NATO's purpose, structure, history, and current operations, the most comprehensive and authoritative source is the Secretary General's Annual Report.

NATO's web site and Twitter/X account also provides a detailed overview of the organization and activities of the Alliance. It is also a useful exercise to familiarize yourself with NATO's founding treaty (from 1949), the 2022 NATO Strategic Concept and recent official documents (those adopted at Wales in 2014, Warsaw in 2016 and Brussels in 2018, as well as the 2019 London Declaration and the June 2021 Brussels Summit Communiqué, the 2022 Madrid Summit Declaration, the 2023 Vilnius summit Communiqué, the 2024 Washington Declaration, the 2025 Hague Declaration and the 2026 Ankara Declaration.

Other useful sites include:

- The Atlantic Council
- Center for Strategic and International Studies (CSIS)
- Chatham House
- European Leadership Network
- NATO Parliamentary Assembly
- NATO Defense College
- NATO Watch
- Royal United Services Institute

A speech given by NATO's first Secretary General, Lord Hastings Ismay, as long ago as 1957 still provides useful insights on how NATO allies should carry out their business.

The best source for national military capabilities is *The Military Balance* published by the International Institute of Strategic Studies in London. You should check if your library takes a subscription. If not, a useful online alternative is Global Firepower. You should also familiarize yourself with NATO's official military expenditure data.

For the national emergency response capabilities of a number of NATO allies, see https://ec.europa.eu/echo/what/civil-protection/national-disaster-management-system_en

For information on individual allies, visit the web sites of their permanent delegations to NATO. See, for instance, the United Kingdom here, and the United States here.